

CHAPTER 1

The Heart and the Word

But blessed are your eyes, for they see, and your ears, for they hear.

— Matthew 13:16 (ESV)

For years, I was better at reading the fruit in other people's lives than at examining the roots of my own. I could sit across from someone and, almost before they finished a sentence, already have a sense of what kind of ground they were. I do not say that with any pride now. It took me a long time to notice I was doing it, and longer still to turn the same question back on myself: what is my life actually producing, and what does that say about the soil underneath it?

That question is not new to me. There is a message I began to preach some time ago, and then a brief interruption came, and I set it down. I did not set it down because I had run out of things to say. After praying about it before the Lord, I decided to go back to the beginning and start again, because I have learned that some questions cannot be answered in a single pass. They have to be returned to, and walked around, and looked at again in a different light. This

is one of those questions, and it is the reason I am writing.

It is a simple question to state. Why is it that some people, when they hear the message of Christ, open their hearts to Him immediately, while others hear the very same words and do not? You may have watched this happen yourself. You share the gospel with someone and they say, at once, "Yes, please. Tell me what I need to do to receive salvation." You share it with someone else, in the same way, with the same words, and nothing moves. I have wondered about that difference for a long time.

I do not have a precise biblical answer to it, and I want to say that plainly at the start. What follows is not a closed doctrine. It comes from years of watching people hear the Word, and I hold it loosely. What I have noticed is that there seem to be two kinds of response. Some people open their hearts immediately, and I have wondered whether they have already lived through something that made a decision for Christ necessary. We often say of such a person that he has hit rock bottom and has nowhere else to turn. The other kind hears, and may even be moved, and then answers, "It is not my time yet. Maybe later I will receive the Word of God."

I ask myself, every time I hear that answer, when that person's time will come. And the more serious question underneath it is whether they will really have the time, when it does, to make things right with God. We never know. That is the part I keep returning to. My father-in-law died at ninety-nine years old, my mother-in-law at eighty-nine, and my father at eighty-six. Death is the law of life, and it comes to every household. You and I look strong today, and healthy, and it is easy to believe that

tomorrow will look like today. Yet none of us knows what may happen between now and the day we leave the place where we are sitting.

I do not say this to frighten anyone. I say it because it is simply the reality of life, and because it is exactly what makes the answer not yet so heavy. It is not the waiting itself that troubles me. It is the possibility that some people wait until there is no longer any opportunity to respond. There may be people who never truly get the chance to make things right with God. I cannot set that thought down, and it is what sent me back into Scripture to look for an explanation.

It was that question, why some hearts respond and others do not, that took me back to the parable of the sower. It is a passage I have read and taught many times, and I went back to it the way one returns to a field one thought was familiar. What I found in it was not new information. It was a different way of seeing what had been there all along. The problem, I began to understand, was never the seed.

I want to stop here for a moment, because this series and this book are built on that parable, and I could easily use it in the wrong way. It would be easy to read the four kinds of ground and think of the people I know. It would be easy to say, "That one is the path, and that one is the rocky ground." But I want to read it the other way around, as a guide for examining my own heart, and I invite you to read it as a guide for examining yours.

Reading Roots, Not Leaves

Some of us grew up in the church and made a profession of faith long ago, and have become confident, thinking, "I am in church, so I am a Christian." Perhaps you believe you are going to heaven. But it does not matter how long we have attended, or how well we have learned the language of the church, its manners, and every one of its songs. If we were raised in a Christian environment and still need to be transformed by the Lord, then this is the time to look deeply at our roots.

There is another group, and I count myself among those who know it well. These are people who truly believe and still struggle, who battle their emotions and the pressure of ordinary life, and who sometimes find themselves thinking, "As a Christian, things are worse for me than they were before." That thought is more common than we admit. It complicates the picture, because it tells us that being in good soil may not look the way we expected. Perhaps what we need to ask is not "Did I respond?" but "Are my roots firmly planted in the Lord, and what is my life actually producing?"

For that question I have found one image helpful. Picture a large, leafy, green tree. From a distance you cannot say what it is. You walk up to it and look for the fruit. This one has mangoes, so it is a mango tree. This one has avocados. Is that one a lemon tree, or an orange tree? There are grapefruit trees too, though I do not know whether they go by that name everywhere. Whatever we call them, the fruit tells us what the tree is. The leaves alone never could. Jesus said, "You will know them by their fruits," and I find

that a quiet way of saying that appearance does not settle the question.

And a tree does not stand alone. It stands in a field, and it is the soil that decides what the tree becomes. So the image leads me back to the seed. If the fruit differs from one life to another, it may not be because of anything that was planted. The word of the kingdom, I have come to understand, is the same for everyone. There is not one gospel for some people and a different gospel for others. Everyone hears the same message and receives the same content. That sameness makes the response more important, not less, because it moves my attention from what was sown to what received it.

That is why I have come to see four kinds of response, and I will describe them here only briefly, before we walk through the parable itself. Some people repent. They confess their sins and begin to live a transformed life before the Lord. Some meet the word with an indifference that grows harder the more they hear, as though each sermon were a small vaccination against the gospel. Some receive it with great enthusiasm, but it does not last, because there is no root. And some remain, and their perseverance produces fruit. The difference between them is not the seed. It is the heart that receives it.

Where the Difference Actually Lives

To understand this better, I went back and read Matthew 13 slowly, and I noticed how carefully Matthew sets the scene. Jesus has left the house that day and is sitting beside the sea. The crowds have gathered so thickly around Him that He gets into a

boat and sits down, while the whole crowd stands on the beach. It is easy to read past that and go straight to the story. But I find that it matters, because the parable begins with people standing on a shore, listening, and each of them is about to receive the same words in a different way.

He tells them that a sower went out to sow. As he sowed, some seeds fell along the path, and the birds came and devoured them. Others fell on rocky ground, where they did not have much soil, and they sprang up immediately, because they had no depth. But when the sun rose they were scorched, and because they had no root they withered. That is the second soil, and it appears quickly. The crop did not take long to emerge, but it burned, because it had no root. Other seeds fell among thorns, and the thorns grew up and choked them. And other seeds fell on good soil and produced grain, some a hundredfold, some sixty, some thirty. He who has ears, let him hear.

Not long after He finishes, the disciples come to Him privately and ask why He teaches this way at all—why not simply say it plainly to everyone standing there? His answer has stayed with me longer than almost anything else in this passage. He tells them that to some it has been given to know the secrets of the kingdom, and to others it has not, and then He quotes the prophet Isaiah: “You will indeed hear but never understand, and you will indeed see but never perceive. For this people’s heart has grown dull.”

Then He turns to the disciples standing in front of Him and says something almost tender by comparison: “Blessed are your eyes, for they see, and your ears, for they hear. For truly, I say to you, many prophets and righteous people longed to see what

you see, and did not see it, and to hear what you hear, and did not hear it.”

I have read that exchange many times without letting it land. What strikes me now is that Jesus does not say the crowd on the beach lacked information. They heard the same parable the disciples heard, word for word, standing in the same place. The difference was not what reached their ears. It was the condition of the heart that received it—dull in one case, blessed in the other, not by talent or timing but by disposition. That is the hinge this whole book turns on, and I did not expect to find it stated so plainly this early in the passage. It is not the seed. It is not even, exactly, the hearing. It is the heart the hearing falls into.

It is in that same private conversation that Jesus goes on to explain each type of ground in turn—the path, the rocky ground, the thorns, the good soil—one by one, in detail. I want to sit with that explanation on its own, later in this book, rather than rush through it here. For now, one line from it is worth pulling forward, because it is where I want to end this chapter’s question: the one sown on good soil, He says, is the one who hears the word and understands it, and bears fruit.

I stayed for a long time with that word, understands. It says that the one sown on good soil is the one who hears the word and understands it, and who bears fruit. All four grounds hear. The path hears, the rocky ground hears, the thorns hear. What separates the good soil from the others is not hearing. It is what happens after. Understanding, in this sentence, is the doorway to fruit, and I do not think we are permitted to keep one without the other. I have heard the honest reply, “I hear the

Word, but I do not understand it." I do not take that as an excuse. I take it as a real confession, and it has a real answer, because the Teacher above all teachers is the Holy Spirit. Every time we come to the Word, we can ask Him to help us understand what we are reading.

Thin Ground and Crowded Ground

There is a shallow kind of faith I have thought about a great deal, one that grows fast and cannot hold when the weather turns. I have met people who do not understand why a Christian should ever have to suffer, because they were told that Christians do not suffer, that Christians do not get sick, that Christians never die. But everyone has to die. That is the law of life, and Christians die too, and it hurts. When a promise is made that suffering will not come, and suffering comes anyway, the discouragement is not really about the affliction. It is about a foundation that was never given the chance to grow deep before the weather turned.

I have heard people say, "Come for your miracle. You do not have to be sick." And I have wondered, quietly, what becomes of someone's faith when the miracle does not arrive. I will come back to what makes a root grow deep later in this book. For now I only want to name the ache, because I have felt it too.

I find something similar in a kind of restlessness I have watched take root in people's lives, and it is a subject on which I have to be careful, because it is easy to say it wrongly. In one sense everything we have is our wealth. A newer car is your wealth. An older one, still running after many years, is also your

wealth, and we should be as grateful for the one that still runs as someone else is for the one fresh off the lot, because both come from above. James says that every good gift and every perfect gift is from above, coming down from the Father of lights. My house may not be a mansion with many bedrooms and a swimming pool, and this suit may not be the most expensive one, but they are what I have, and I am called to care for them well. That is not the restlessness I mean.

I mean a restlessness that no amount of having can settle. A person has something, and then no longer wants it, and now wants more, and then more again, and is never satisfied. It is not wrong to have good things. The trouble begins when I exchange what is best for what is lesser, and value material things more than spiritual riches. When that happens the word is still in me, but it cannot breathe, and it becomes ineffective and barren. Jesus said not to lay up treasures on earth, where moths and rust destroy and thieves break in. You save and you work hard, and then someone takes it, because we live in a fallen world. Yet those who have not understood this become anxious and consumed by worry.

And this restlessness has quieter forms. One is competition: that person has that, so I want it too, and that person is like that, so I want to be like that. All of this grows from not wanting to appear smaller than anyone else. I have come to think that true success is something different. It is the satisfaction of knowing that you are fulfilling the purpose for which God created you and placed you in this world. Someone who has a great deal may still be unsatisfied, and that may only mean they have not found the purpose they were made for. A person who

compares himself with everyone around him, and starts doing things while forgetting the Word, has a word in him that will bear no fruit.

Another form shows up around worship itself. I understand that some people have work obligations and must answer to an employer, and I do not mean them. I mean those who say, almost desperately, "I did not make enough this week, so I have to do something instead of setting this time apart," and then tell themselves they can still make it up later. Deep down they know they will not. What troubles me is not which day it is; it is the quiet decision that whatever I can see and touch matters more, this time, than whatever I cannot.

Someone says, "But God knows my need." He does. And if God knows my need, then by giving Him this time I am giving Him room to provide, while by withholding it I am giving up the very opportunity for Him to bless me. Because our eyes are fixed on what we can see and touch, we miss that.

What We Call a Blessing

For many years I have stood at the door of the church after a message, and I have heard nearly every kind of comment about it. When I say my preaching, I mean the exposition, which is God's message delivered through me. Some people say, "Pastor, what a message!" And some add, cheerfully, "I just ate a huge steak, Pastor," as if the message had been one more good meal. I do not tell you this to feel superior to them. I have to ask the same question of myself. What I have learned at that door is that the feeling of being moved and the act of obeying are two

different things. I hear the message, I feel something, and then comes the question of what I do. I have watched the same people, days later, make decisions that dishonor the Lord, and I have wondered what good the meal did.

That is what led me to question how we talk about blessing. God does bless His children, and I believe that with everything in me. But I do not believe His blessing is expressed through a mystical system. When I hesitate to tell someone that God is about to bless them, I am not saying that He cannot. I am saying that He may not do it in the way I describe it, or others describe it, or certain preachers describe it. I believe the blessing comes when we hear the Word, obey the Word, and are transformed by the Word.

And I have heard it said, "Claim the blessings of God. You are the child of a King." I do not see anywhere in Scripture that I am commanded to claim blessings. I see that I am commanded to obey, and that God's blessing follows obedience. Whatever comes into our lives, whether possessions or progress, if it does not come through obedience, I do not think it is God's blessing, because the heart is not yet ready to receive it.

I know this may sound negative, and I hope it does not. I am not trying to take anyone's joy, and I am not negative in any way. I am trying to look at what the Word says, and to bring us gently to the reality of it.

There is a story I have heard so many times that I recognize it at once. A young woman in the church knows the Word. She knows that Scripture says not to be unequally yoked with unbelievers. In simple terms, she knows that a son or daughter of God should not marry someone who does not believe in

the Lord. Then she marries someone who does not know Him. When her parents raise the concern, the answer is nearly always the same: "He is not a Christian, but he is a good person. He works. He has a car. He is very kind." And before the wedding, she often says something else, and says it with sincerity: "I am going to win him for Christ."

I do not answer that with a verse first. I ask a question, and I ask it as gently as I can. How many people have you led to Christ so far? How many have you shared the gospel with? Sometimes the answer is none, and that tells me something. It does not mean she cannot do it. It means that "I will win him" may be carrying more weight than it can bear, because it is standing in for the obedience that was supposed to come first. I recognize the shape of that hope, too, because I have reached for gentler versions of it myself, when what I wanted was already decided. If the true child of God says, "I want to please God," then the question is not whether the man is good. It is whether the principle was listened to.

The principle is not there because God wants to keep us from relationships. He knows that the mismatch will bring consequences into a marriage. And there is a further thing I have seen, which is that a person does not have to marry an unbeliever to find the thorns in a home.

A man may be a Christian who knows a great deal about the Bible and obeys very little of it. He knows he is supposed to be the head of his household, but he does not set the example, and he is not the spiritual leader of the home. He does not honor his wife as the Bible says, and he makes jokes about her in front of his friends. You do not have to live in the world to be worldly. You do not have to be drunk to

be worldly. You only have to disobey God, and one can do that while reading one's Bible every day. When I say this, the room often becomes very quiet, and I understand why. Very often we do not connect God's truth with our real and practical life. It is the same soil, in every case, just wearing a different shape.

There is a story about a truck that I keep thinking about, and it is a gentle one. I have often been asked, "Pastor, pray for my son." When I ask what he needs, the answer is, "He needs a house and a good job. He has this huge truck, Pastor. God has blessed him." And I hesitate, because I am not sure what a truck has to do with obedience. I would love to hear a young man say, "Pastor, let us take a four-wheel-drive vehicle into the mountains to preach the gospel." That is what a truck like that could be for. But that is not what it is for in the stories I hear.

If a child is not obeying God, a house given to him apart from obedience is not a blessing. It is a possession, and it may even harm him. A salary increase can be a blessing from God and, in a heart that is not ready to obey, become a curse, because that heart will use everything it receives to dishonor Him. So when others gather to pray for their children, I would ask, very gently, that we not attribute something to God as a blessing when it did not come through obedience.

The truck itself was never the problem, any more than the seed is ever the problem. It was only ever a question of what ground it fell on.

Weighing Scripture Against Ourselves

All of this brings me back to the question I began with, why the same message is received so differently. Sometimes we wonder whether the problem is in the message itself. Was the preacher not anointed enough for the Word to reach people's hearts? Would a more creative method have changed the result? I do not believe so, and Matthew 12 helps me see why. Jesus has just healed a man who was blind and mute and oppressed by a demon, so that the man could speak and see. The crowds are amazed and ask, "Can this be the Son of David?" But when the Pharisees hear it, they say that it is only by Beelzebul, the prince of demons, that this man casts out demons.

I stop here, because this may be the clearest example in Scripture of what I am trying to say. The light of God was standing directly in front of them. The Word was right in front of the Pharisees, and they chose to reject it. Their problem was not that the evidence was missing. It was the posture in which they stood before it. They did not come to learn. They came with uncomfortable questions, trying to catch Jesus in a mistake, and to embarrass Him in front of the crowds. John says the Light came into the world and people loved the darkness rather than the Light. And when someone comes to question, and challenge, and expose, that person becomes more confused, and not less.

This is the same dullness of heart Jesus named to His disciples earlier—not an absence of evidence, but a heart not disposed to receive it. I think of Nicodemus here. He was a teacher of the law, and yet he could not grasp what it meant to be born

again, and I think it was because he came with an arrogant heart. We do not know for certain what became of him, though there is an indication, in the help he gave after the crucifixion, that he may have been saved. The other Pharisees kept coming with their questions, saying, "That cannot be from God, because we know the law." But they did not understand the gospel. They were so blinded by their religion that they could not see the light of it.

That is where I have to ask the question of myself. With what attitude do I come before the Lord? With what attitude do I come to hear the Word? I can come to question, and to see whether God's Word fits my life. I can say, "If the Bible says this, why is it not happening in mine?" And then I begin to question Scripture on the basis of my own experience, and I ask how anyone is going to answer the concern I have. Or I can ask something different: what are God's answers for me, so that I can apply His principles to my life, honor His name, and allow Him to transform my heart? I think, for most of us, our experience is more important than Scripture, and we do not notice it.

I have heard, more than once, an idea that doubting at the very last moment of life means a person never truly belonged to God at all. Sincere believers read Scripture differently on this than I do, and I do not think this chapter is the place to settle it. What actually interests me is something underneath it—how easily an idea, repeated often enough, starts to feel like truth on its own weight, whether or not anyone ever tested it against the Word itself.

I have seen the same thing with forgiveness, only the stakes are much higher. Someone has hurt you deeply. That person has destroyed your family, and

ended the trust you had in him. You grew up together, and you respected that person because of his position, and he failed you. You say, "Do not even think that I am going to forgive him, because he does not deserve it." It is the kind of line we hear in television soap operas, and we adopt it without noticing: when someone causes me irreparable harm, that person does not deserve my forgiveness.

Then the pastor says, "Look at what the Bible says. You have to forgive." And the answer comes, "Well, the Bible may say that. But no one knows what I feel. You cannot understand what I am carrying inside." I do not doubt that it is true. But in that moment, what I feel has become more important than what God says. That is a kind of blindness, and it is disobedience to the Word of God. It is not the seed. It is the heart that receives it.

What God Changes, What We Lay Down

I have had to learn something, more slowly than I would like, and it may be the most freeing thing in this whole chapter. There are things God changes, and there are things I must surrender. Many people believe God has to change everything. But biblically, there are things He changes, and there are things He asks me to put down. I think two errors sit on either side of it. One is believing I can change myself without God. The other is expecting God to do everything while I remain passive.

Ephesians 4 says it in a way I cannot get around. Paul writes that we must no longer walk as the Gentiles do, in the futility of their minds, darkened in their understanding, and alienated from the life of

God because of the ignorance in them and the hardness of their hearts. Then he says, "But that is not the way you learned Christ." It does not say according to my feelings, or according to my emotions. It says according to the truth that is in Jesus. I may not feel like forgiving, but the truth that is in Jesus says to forgive, whether I feel like it or not.

And then come the words that changed how I read all of this: "Put off your old self, which belongs to your former manner of life and is corrupt through deceitful desires." Who is going to put it off? I am. It does not say that God will take it from me. It says I must put it off, and be renewed in the spirit of my mind, and put on the new self. These are all commands, and it does not only say to take off the old. It also says to put on the new. I have asked myself how much time I invest in putting on the new, and the answer to that is not always comfortable. It is why we read the Bible: so that we can understand God's will, and hear Him speak to our hearts.

When I stand in front of a temptation, I already know it is not from God. I know it. At that moment I can ignore the Holy Spirit, and ignore the presence of God within me, and fall headfirst into it. Or I can say, "Lord, here I am. You are with me. Your Holy Spirit is in me. Give me strength, and today I choose, in the name of Jesus, to reject this." I have come to believe this is what the power of the Holy Spirit is for. It is not for putting on a circus show. It is for surrendering sin. And He is a real Person, God's Paraclete, my personal Counselor, speaking to my ear and saying, "That is not the way."

I have heard the question, "Why do I never change?" and I have wondered whether the honest answer may be that we never surrender. We want

God to take responsibility for us, but if we surrender, we become responsible for our actions.

And it is uncomfortable to say how concrete this is. Why do we lie? Why do we steal? Why do we distrust other people, and speak badly about them, and gossip about them? Why do we love watching other people's lives instead of examining our own? I think it is because we are enslaved to it, in a way we do not like to admit. Paul says to let no corrupting talk come out of our mouths, but only what is good for building up. We do not put things off quickly, and we sometimes try to live comfortably with our foul language, or our anger, or our envy.

So the question is not only "Can God change me?" It is also "What have I not put down?" It is not that we cannot. We have the power, because we were sealed by the Holy Spirit until the day of redemption. It is that we do not always want to use it. God is not going to take away my lying, or my stealing. I have to surrender them.

Looking in the Wrong Field

There is a story I want to tell, because it is one that helped me to understand why the written Word matters so much. People often say, "I am looking for a prophet to tell me God's will." But Peter says that the prophetic Word is more certain, and that we do well to pay attention to it, to hear it and obey it. I want to tell you what happened once, at a camp where I had been asked to share the program with a well-known prophet.

We were shown to a small room prepared for us, and my wife and I walked in holding hands. The host

introduced us—Pastor Oziel Guzmán, and the prophet—and without any hesitation, the prophet looked at my wife and asked me, “Where did you find her?” I was taken aback. There is a saying, not a biblical one, that people think everyone is like they are, and I remember thinking of it. I say it not to condemn him, but because it was the first thing that made me wonder.

During the ministry time I watched him touch people, and one after another they fell. But there was a young man whom he touched who did not fall. He touched him again, and he did not fall. He touched him a third time, and still he did not fall. The young man was frightened. In the end the prophet placed his hand on him and practically forced him to the floor, as though to say, “You are either going to fall, or I am going to make you fall.” Once he was on the ground he did not get up. He stayed there, frightened.

Later, during one of the activities, I was paired with him. I do not think it was by chance. I believe God placed me there to speak with him. I asked him how he felt, and he said, “I am completely confused. I did not expect this.” Everyone else there already knew what they had come for, but he did not. As we talked, it became clear that he was carrying a family history too painful to speak of easily, the kind that leaves a person asking where they even belong. He had come looking for hope, and what he found instead was confusion.

It caused me tremendous pain. I thought of how much time we spend on things that are not from God, when the surest prophetic Word is right in front of us, and it is the Word that transforms the heart. I do not tell this story to say that God cannot work in

unusual ways. I tell it because I wonder why we go looking where we should not, when we already have the Word. I think the reason, sometimes, is that we want someone else to tell us what to do, not so that we can seek counsel, but so that we can find an accomplice. If it goes wrong, we can say, "The prophet told me," or "The pastor told me."

That young man did not need a spectacle performed over a field no one had ever plowed. He needed the same soil-deep work this whole chapter is about—the clear voice of God in Scripture, reaching all the way down to the root of things.

All of this, the question I began with, the stories, the passages I have gone back to, brings me to the same place. The seed has not changed. The Word of God is the same for everyone, and in every case it is powerful, and perfect, and without error. What differs is the soil. I said at the beginning that I could not put down the question of why some people respond and others do not, and I have not answered it as a doctrine. But I think I have learned to ask it differently. It is not the seed, and it is not the message, and it is not the preacher. It is the heart.

I do not know what kind of soil you are. I do not think I am the one who can say. Perhaps you are the path, and perhaps the rocky ground, and perhaps you are among the thorns, or perhaps you are good soil and have never quite believed it. I hold that question for myself as well. It is a question that changes the original one. It moves it from "Why do other people respond so differently?" to "What is happening in me?" And I think it is only from there that anything begins to grow.

I am not asking for a heroic response. I am not asking for a public declaration, or for anyone to raise

a hand. I would only ask that you give yourself permission to be honest before God about where your heart truly is, and about whether there is anything in it you are holding that you might put down. He sees your heart. And when honesty comes in, grace can finally do its work.